# Caspar Friedrich Wolff — Theoria generationis (1759)

*The Boneyard is a collection of works left unfinished, unpublished, or unread at their authors' deaths — dry bones in the valley, in Ezekiel's image. Each presentation tells the scholar's story, weighs what survives of his work, and states plainly what completing it would take, so that a book the world never received whole can be met at last. Each of them was one of one. There will never be another like him, and his light will not shine again except through the work he left behind.*

A Boneyard dossier — researched and presented by Robert Tilford, Hays, Kansas. Filed 14 October 2026.

Disclosure: prepared with AI assistance — the subject reviewers are AI agents, each desk-checked at this desk; all rulings and final decisions are the author's own.

## Dedication

This edition is dedicated to Caspar Friedrich Wolff (1733/34–1794), whose Halle dissertation of 1759, *Theoria generationis*, founded epigenesis against the reigning doctrine of preformation. Albrecht von Haller was a powerful antagonist, and Wolff could not get academic footing in Berlin. He served as a field surgeon during the Seven Years' War, and only in 1767, with Euler's help, did he obtain the anatomy chair at St. Petersburg. The dedication honours a scholar who held to his account of how organisms form — in differentiated layers, out of material at first undifferentiated — through rejection and war service, until a chair at last gave him a place to work.

## The author's own terms

Wolff called the force that drives that formation the *vis essentialis*, the essential force: by it, organs are formed in differentiated layers out of material at first undifferentiated.

## The story

Caspar Friedrich Wolff (1733/34–1794) published his Halle dissertation, *Theoria generationis*, in 1759, and with it founded epigenesis. Epigenesis is the doctrine

that an organism develops by the gradual formation of new structures, rather than unfolding from a miniature version of itself already present from the start. That second, reigning doctrine was preformation, and Wolff argued against it.

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The work is in three parts: the development of plants; the development of animals; and theoretical considerations. Organs, in its central picture, are formed in differentiated layers out of material at first undifferentiated, driven by a force Wolff called the *vis essentialis*, the essential force.

Wolff published the dissertation in Latin at Halle in 1759, and again in 1774. His German *Theorie von der Generation* (Berlin, 1764) is not a mere translation. It is a revised, polemical restatement attacking Haller and Bonnet — which is why a translator must first decide which Wolff to translate.

## The work and what survives

The dates are 1759, 1764, and 1774, and the author died in 1794. The work is in the public domain everywhere relevant.

The first edition is recorded as Halle: Hendel, 1759, an inaugural dissertation. The *editio nova*, the new edition, is Halle: Hendel, 1774. The Wellcome catalogue records that 1774 edition as lxiv + 231 pages, with 2 folded plates, and Wellcome holds select images only.

A scan question ran through two rounds of checking. In the first second-pass check, five targeted passes — through the Internet Archive under multiple phrasings, MDZ/BSB, GDZ Göttingen, BHL, Wellcome, and Google Books — surfaced no openable scan of the Latin text. That result is stated in the record as a non-result, not evidence of absence. The build-time pull list was given in order: MDZ/BSB, ULB Halle digital collections, GDZ, HathiTrust, BHL.

A later check, using a differently phrased Internet Archive census, found what those searches had missed. The scan pin is discharged in part. Internet Archive `b30506256` is the 1774 *editio nova* — Halle: Hendel; lxiv + 231 pages; 2 folded plates; ark:/13960/t3fz4zb4t; full text present — matching the Wellcome catalogue record field for field. A second copy is

`theoriagenerati00wolfgoog`. The 1764 German text is pinned at Internet Archive `11270154bsb`, from BSB. The 1759 first edition remains unpinned, but the base-text choice is now three-way, with two texts in hand: the 1759 text, still to pull; the 1774 revised-and-enlarged Latin, in hand; and the 1764 German, in hand.

One caution stands in full. Do not build from the Samassa German alone if the claim is “the 1759 dissertation.” Samassa's edition is the German edition in Ostwalds Klassiker 84–85 (1896). The caution stands for a “1759 dissertation” claim specifically.

## Its English fortunes

In the standard bibliography, the modern editions listed are German, Russian, and a photo-reprint: Samassa's German edition of 1896; a Russian edition of 1950; and a Hildesheim photo-reprint of 1966. No English edition is listed. English scholarship — Roe 1981 is the example given — quotes passages, including §168 and §242, in its own ad-hoc translation: translations made for the occasion, as excerpts, not as an edition.

The original finding was: no complete English translation found after research.

The later primacy-hardening check cleared that position and made it census-backed. It stands across the Internet Archive, in an 8-item census with no English; the OpenLibrary edition graph, which gives Latin and German only, with Wheeler 1899 identified as a study about Wolff; OpenAlex works and dissertations, which returned nothing; the *Dictionary of Scientific Biography* bibliography, re-read for the purpose, giving modern editions in German in 1896, Russian in 1950, and a photo-reprint in 1966, with no English; and current scholarly practice, in which a 2022 journal article still translates the 1759 passages itself.

The licensed wording at announcement, as recorded in the dossier, is: **the first English translation of the *Theoria generationis***, bounded by those routes and the 2026-10-14 date, with the build's base-text ruling stated on its face.

## What completing it would take

A ruling on the base text is still needed. The options, as the choice now stands, are three-way: (a) the 1759 Latin, pure and shortest, still to pull; (b) the 1774

Latin, revised and enlarged, in hand; or (c) the 1764 German, fuller and polemical, in hand. The earlier framing of the choice — between the 1759 Latin and the 1764 German — remains part of the record, and the ruling remains Robert Tilford's to make.

Either of the originally framed options is a single short volume, and the dossier describes the work as the fastest completable masterwork in its report. It pairs with Pander's work and with volume I of Von Baer's work as a possible “Germ Layers” grouping.

## Sources


- https://encyclopedia.com/topic/Caspar_Friedrich_Wolff.aspx (editions list; the 1812 Meckel intestine memoir)
- https://alchetron.com/Caspar-Friedrich-Wolff (structure; Haller antagonism)
- https://philarchive.org/archive/DETEAD (scholarship quoting in ad-hoc translation)
- https://resolve.cambridge.org/core/services/aop-cambridge-core/content/view/8285C001F9E251A26B3A48266D83552B/S0025727300013491a.pdf (1966 reprint review)